FARMLIFE

KCFB KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

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June in Motion: Stakeholders Take the Lead on SGMA Across the Tulare Lake Subbasin

From allocation planning to well registration tools, local leaders are doing the hard work of groundwater management.

by Julie Martella

Momentum continues to build across the Tulare Lake Subbasin. Far from dragging their feet, local stakeholder committees and GSA boards are taking the necessary steps to revise their Groundwater Sustainability Plans (GSPs) and meet the state's expectations. These conversations are specific, strategic, and transparent, providing a clear picture of how the region is tackling SGMA from the ground up.

This month's meetings confirmed what many already recognize: implementing SGMA takes work, and the region is stepping up to meet that responsibility. Conversations are direct and sometimes intense—not because people disagree, but because they care. From well registration to allocation planning, stakeholders are engaging and helping shape the policies that will define our future.

Shared Focus: Native Yield, Transitional Water, and Subsidence

Several important concepts are beginning to take shape across the subbasin. Among them, native yield, transitional water allocation, and subsidence are emerging as central to long-term groundwater planning.

Native yield is a working estimate of the amount of groundwater that is naturally recharged into the basin each year. It includes sources like underflow, precipitation, seepage, and return flows. This number will serve as the foundation for future allocation frameworks, and discussions are underway to better understand how it varies by zone and how it might be applied.

Transitional water refers to groundwater use that exceeds native yield during the adjustment period. Stakeholders have started early conversations about what this might look like over time, including how it could help balance immediate operational needs with long-term goals.

Subsidence remains a regional concern, particularly in areas near infrastructure. While not every GSA addresses it in the same way, it remains part of the broader conversation about sustainable groundwater use and responsibility.

These topics are still in early stages, and no final policies have been adopted. What's clear is that stakeholders are engaging with both the science and the strategy behind them, and that the conversation is just beginning.

Mid-Kings: Grounded Progress in Policy and Tools

The Mid-Kings Stakeholder Advisory Committee continued its in-depth review of draft policies related to well registration, shallow well mitigation, and water measurement.

Well Registration: Stakeholders reaffirmed that wells should be registered within 90 days of pulling a permit. If completion falls outside that window, landowners should notify the GSA. To support this effort, the GSA is developing a new software system that will streamline and organize the registration process, making it easier to track compliance.

Shallow Well Mitigation: The committee reviewed a potential program funded by pumping fees and grants. The focus remains on providing timely support for domestic wells that may go dry while ensuring clarity and fairness in the claims process.

Stakeholder Oversight: Members are providing line-by-line feedback, offering practical adjustments based on real-world experience. Their engagement is helping turn broad mandates into usable tools.

The committee's work is a strong example of what it means to take SGMA seriously and act locally.

South Fork Kings: A Shift Toward Policy Action and Representation

The South Fork Kings GSA Board met in May to discuss key planning efforts underway.

Water Allocation Drafting: The board discussed preliminary concepts tied to native yield and transitional tiers. Although no formal action was taken, the conversation signaled a shift toward establishing a structured allocation framework.

Subsidence Coordination: Recognizing the shared impacts of land subsidence, the board emphasized the need for continued alignment with neighboring GSAs in the Tulare Lake Subbasin. Mitigation strategies will need to be coordinated across boundaries.

Board Representation: There was discussion about possibly expanding the board to better represent growers and underrepresented areas. This step would address long-standing concerns about balanced governance and stakeholder access.

These early efforts mark a shift from general awareness to hands-on design, with more formal policy development expected in the coming months.

Tri-County Water Authority: Integrating Across Subbasins

Tri-County Water Authority's May meeting focused on aligning draft policy decisions across the Tulare Lake, Tule, and North Management Zone subbasins.

Allocation Planning: Staff shared initial figures and proposed definitions for native yield and transitional water.

"SGMA" continued on page 13

KCFB
KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

Purpose
Protect, preserve and enhance agriculture in Kings County

Vision
Ensure that every farmer has the right to farm and protect their heritage

Values
Our Members | Proactive Representative
Reliable | Trusted Resource

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KCFB Executive Director's Report

Groundwater on the Line: Where KCFB's Lawsuit Stands— and Why Your Support Still Matters

By Dusty Ference, Executive Director

Dusty Ference

A Brief Status Check

- Injunction Holds. The preliminary injunction issued by Kings County Superior Court last fall still blocks the State Water Resources Control Board (SWRCB) from enforcing its probation-era groundwater program. That means no $300-per-well annual fee, no $20-per-acre-foot pumping charge, and no state-mandated metering or reporting—at least for now.
- Appeal Pending. All briefs have been filed with the Fifth District Court of Appeal in Fresno. The court may schedule oral argument, but could also rule directly from the written record. Until a decision is handed down, the injunction remains in force.
- You're Shielded—for the Moment. If you receive any invoice or notice from the SWRCB, remember the injunction protects you. Contact KCFB if you have questions.

Why This Fight Matters

- Local Control First. SGMA promised groundwater would be managed locally through Groundwater Sustainability Agencies (GSAs). The state's "probation" model flips that principle on its head.
- Economic Survival. Sudden, punitive fees threaten farm viability, jobs, and the broader Kings County economy.
- Statewide Precedent. A defeat here opens the door for Sacramento to impose the same regime on every basin in California.

How You Can Help Right Now

- Stay Active in Your GSA. Show up, speak up, keep local plans moving forward.
- Watch for KCFB Alerts. We will notify you the moment the appellate court acts.
- Spread the Word. Remind neighbors and local leaders that the injunction is temporary—unity is essential.
- Strengthen the Defense Fund. Legal battles are costly. Every contribution helps us retain top counsel, fund expert testimony, and keep the farm community informed.

We're Not Going Anywhere

For more than a century, the Kings County Farm Bureau has been the voice of local agriculture. That commitment does not pause while the legal clock ticks. We will stand in the courtroom, the Capitol, and the community until this issue is resolved—and long after—to protect the water rights that keep our farms, families, and food supply thriving.

Thank you for your membership, your donations, and your steadfast resolve. Together, we will secure a groundwater future that works for farmers and the communities we nourish.

Have questions or need to confirm your SGMA Defense Fund pledge?
Call us at (559) 584-3557
Email kcfb@kcfb.org

Help Shape USDA Conservation Funding in Kings County

KCFB and the Excelsior-Kings River Resource Conservation District (EKRCD) are working closely with the USDA's Natural Resources Conservation Service (NRCS) to ensure that federal conservation funding is targeted where it's needed most—right here in Kings County.

As part of this effort, we will be circulating a brief survey asking local growers to share their opinions about conservation priorities, funding practices, and resource concerns. This feedback will directly influence the types of projects NRCS funds and how much money could be dedicated to our area for the upcoming fiscal year.

The survey is part of the Local Working Group (LWG) process, which NRCS uses to identify priority resource concerns, update funding criteria, and adjust conservation practice payment rates. Your participation ensures that the voice of Kings County agriculture is heard when federal conservation programs are developed.

By taking a few minutes to complete the survey, you'll be helping shape decisions that impact everything from water use and soil health to air quality and rangeland improvement. KCFB and EKRCD are committed to making sure Kings County growers get the resources they need to address real, on-the-ground challenges.

Look for the survey in your inbox or on our website in the coming days. We encourage every grower to participate and help guide meaningful, locally informed conservation investment in our region.

For questions about the survey or how your input will be used, feel free to contact the KCFB office.

Put earnings back in your pocket with competitive borrowing rates and an annual cash dividend through our Patronage Program.

In 2024, AgWest paid the equivalent of 1.25% of eligible average daily loan balances back to our customer-owners.

AgWestFC.com

AgWest FARM CREDIT

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This institution is an equal opportunity provider and employer.

Content for this month's "Ag News in Brief," provided by the California Farm Bureau Federation

Lawmakers attack governor's plan to streamline Delta tunnel

Fifteen California lawmakers from both parties are up in arms over Gov. Gavin Newsom's latest proposal to use the budget process to fast-track the Delta tunnel — a deeply controversial, $20 billion plan to replumb the estuary and funnel more water south. With the clock ticking for the Legislature to pass a budget bill tackling the state's $12 billion deficit, Newsom dropped a spending plan that would add sweeping changes to permitting, litigation, financing, and eminent domain and land acquisition issues aimed at speeding approval of the massive project. *CalMatters.*

Land conversion money available for Tulare County farmers, others, to cut groundwater use

Growers hoping for a lifeline as groundwater pumping restrictions tighten learned how to apply for state funding to find other uses for their irrigated farmland during a seminar in Tulare County. The funding is part of a $1.5 million pot from the Kaweah subbasin Multibenefit Land Repurposing Program (MLRP). Growers and others can apply for between $50,000 and $200,000 to fund land transition projects through Aug. 31. "It's hard to farm with the amount of water the state says we can use," said Dee Dee Gruber, who attended the seminar with her husband, Tom Gruber, and about 25 others. *SJV Water.*

California unveils wolf mapping tool to help avoid conflicts with livestock

California ranchers have a new mapping tool designed to provide regular location information on GPS-collared gray wolves in the state to help prevent wolf-livestock conflicts. Provided by the California Department of Fish and Wildlife, the wolf tracker shows the approximate location of collared wolves across the state. "Knowing where California's collared wolf population is means that ranchers have access to critical information," said California Farm Bureau President Shannon Douglass. "We appreciate CDFW's focus on transparency to help farmers and ranchers navigate the growing number of wolves in the state."

Groundwater is rapidly declining in the Colorado River Basin, satellite data show

As the Colorado River's giant reservoirs have declined during the last two decades, even larger amounts of water have been pumped and drained from underground, according to new research based on data from NASA satellites. Scientists at Arizona State University examined more than two decades of satellite measurements and found that since 2003 the quantity of groundwater depleted in the Colorado River Basin is comparable to the total capacity of Lake Mead, the nation's largest reservoir. *Los Angeles Times.*

USDA to Provide $1 Billion to Livestock Producers Impacted by Drought or Wildfire in 2023 and 2024

Assistance for Flood-Impacted Producers Coming Summer 2025

U.S. Secretary of Agriculture Brooke L. Rollins recently announced the release of Congressionally mandated Emergency Livestock Relief Program (ELRP) payments to cover grazing losses due to eligible drought or wildfire events in 2023 and/or 2024. Secretary Rollins committed on May 7 to release these emergency payments by May 30, and today she is delivering on that commitment ahead of schedule.

The U.S. Department of Agriculture's (USDA) Farm Service Agency (FSA) is leveraging existing Livestock Forage Disaster Program (LFP) data to streamline payment calculations and expedite relief. Emergency relief payments are automatically issued for producers who have an approved LFP application on file for 2023 and/or 2024.

The American Relief Act, 2025, provided funds for emergency relief payments. This program is the first of two programs authorized to assist with eligible losses suffered by livestock producers. FSA will announce additional ELRP assistance for other losses authorized by the Act, including flooding, later this summer.

FSA Offers Disaster Assistance for Qualifying Tree, Bush and Vine Losses

If you're an orchardist or nursery tree grower whose experienced losses from natural disasters during calendar year 2025, you must submit a TAP application either 90 calendar days after the disaster event or the date when the loss is apparent.

TAP provides financial assistance to help you replant or rehabilitate eligible trees, bushes and vines damaged by natural disasters.

Eligible tree types include trees, bushes or vines that produce an annual crop for commercial purposes. Nursery trees include ornamental, fruit, nut and Christmas trees that are produced for commercial sale. Trees used for pulp or timber are ineligible.

To qualify for TAP, orchardists must suffer a qualifying tree, bush or vine loss in excess of 15 percent mortality from an eligible natural disaster, plus an adjustment for normal mortality. The eligible trees, bushes or vines must have been owned when the natural disaster occurred; however, eligible growers are not required to own the land on which the eligible trees, bushes and vines were planted.

If the TAP application is approved, the eligible trees, bushes and vines must be replaced within 12 months from the date the application is approved. The cumulative total quantity of acres planted to trees, bushes or vines, for which you can receive TAP payments, cannot exceed 1,000 acres annually.

British Consumers Are Skeptical of American Meat. Can They Change?

Just a few days after the United States and Britain announced to much fanfare that they had agreed to lower some tariffs and create a $5 billion export opportunity for American beef, ethanol and other agricultural products in Britain, Brooke Rollins, the U.S. secretary of agriculture, touched down in London… Despite last the provisional agreement, differences in food production could make it difficult for Britain and the United States to reach a more comprehensive trade agreement, and for American farmers to materially increase their exports to Britain. *The New York Times.*

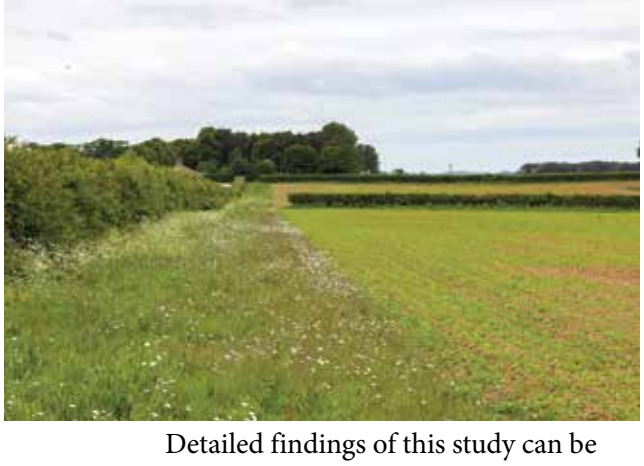
The Kings County Farm Bureau distributes Ag News in Brief to its members only for information. Some story links may require website registration.
Opinions expressed in stories, commentaries, or editorials included in Ag News in Brief do not necessarily represent the views of the Kings County Farm Bureau.

Hedgerow buzz is not just for the bees!

by Mandeep Riar, PhD Restoration Ecology and Weed Science Advisor

"Hedgerows" may sound like a new buzz word for regenerative agriculture, but it has been a part of farming systems for thousands of years. In Europe, especially in Great Britain, hedgerows began as early as the Bronze Age and became widespread by the medieval period. Those hedgerows primarily served to mark property lines, keep livestock in, and as windbreaks. However, in the early United States, Hedgerow plantings were not very common. One of the biggest examples of utilizing hedgerows can be traced back to 1930s when the U.S. Department of Agriculture's Shelterbelt Program promoted shelterbelts and windbreaks to prevent soil erosion in the Midwest. Though hedgerows were never as popular in the US compared to Europe, they have made a comeback in the recent decade as a useful tool for conservation agriculture. In the context of Southern California's intensively managed agricultural landscapes, hedgerows are not a common practice and are often perceived as inefficient land uses, economically non-productive strips that compete for water and complicate mechanized operations. However, emerging research and field trials suggest that hedgerows provide critical ecosystem services that may offset, or even exceed, the opportunity costs of the land they occupy.

One of the primary benefits of hedgerows is pollinator support. Hedgerows enhance the native bee richness and abundance, leading to improved pollination services in adjacent fields. For Southern California growers of pollination-dependent crops such as almonds, strawberries, melons, and avocados, the presence of hedgerows with sequentially blooming native species can significantly enhance pollinator presence during critical flowering windows. Hedgerows also act as natural pest control by attracting and harboring natural enemies of agricultural pests, including predatory beetles, syrphid flies, parasitic wasps, and spiders, which prey on aphids and mites. This reduces the need for chemical sprays, saving money and decreasing the harmful impacts on the environment.



But the benefits of hedgerows are not limited to bees and beneficial insects. Established hedgerows improve soil and water management by reducing water runoff after rain, reducing wind erosion and dust, and stabilizing soil on slopes. Woody perennial hedgerows also act as carbon sinks, storing biomass both above and below ground. Their shading and windbreak functions contribute to microclimate regulation, buffering crops from heat extremes and desiccating winds. Additionally, recent studies published by University of California Agriculture and Natural Resources (Long and Valliere, 2025) have shown that hedgerows can reduce weed pressure along field borders and adjacent interiors of the field. Detailed findings of this study can be found at "Long RF, Valliere JM. Established native hedgerows on field borders suppress weeds on farms. Weed Science. 2025;73: e33. doi:10.1017/wsc.2025.2. or by emailing at mriar@ucanr.edu.

For Southern California, hedgerows should be designed with native, drought-tolerant plants like California lilac, toyon, yarrow, buckwheat, and milkweed. These species require little irrigation once established and provide year-round value to wildlife. As California farmers try to adapt to changing weather, stricter regulations, and tighter margins, hedgerows can boost resilience without sacrificing productivity.

SGMA DEFENSE FUND

Join the Fight!

Kings County Farm Bureau's legal challenge against the State Water Resources Control Board has already saved growers in the Tulare Lake Sub-basin millions of dollars and kept state intervention off your farm. But the fight isn't over yet—and we need your support to finish strong. By contributing, you'll play a crucial role in securing a win for California agriculture, protecting farms, and ensuring the future of farming in California. This is a pivotal moment—your support can make all the difference.
Join us in defending California's agricultural community!

Call 559-584-3557
Email kcfb@kcfb.org
or visit our website www.kcfb.org for more information

HOW YOU CAN HELP:

$15 PER ACRE ASSESSMENT:

GROWERS IN THE TULARE SUB-BASIN
GSA ORGANIZATIONS
GROWERS OUTSIDE THE TULARE SUB-BASIN

BUSINESS SUPPORT LEVELS:

BRONZE DONOR:	$2,500
SILVER DONOR:	$5,000
GOLD DONOR:	$10,000
DIAMOND DONOR:	$25,000

Please make checks payable to:

Kings County Farm Bureau
870 Greenfield Ave.,
Hanford, CA
93230

Include SGMA Defense Fund on the memo line

MEMBERSHIP APPRECIATION NIGHT

Thursday, May 8, 2025

EXCELSIOR/KINGS RIVER
Resource Conservation District

Healthy Soils Grant Program

Excelsior Kings River RCD will cost share projects aimed at improving on-farm soil health and on-farm composting

OBJECTIVE

Cost share healthy soils projects including but not limited to:
compost applications, mulching, cover-cropping and whole orchard recycling

SERVICE AREA

Portions of Kings, Tulare, and Fresno Counties

**Members of the Socially Disadvantaged Farmers and Ranchers (SDFR) Community are encouraged to apply and may qualify for additional funding.*

APPLICATION TIMELINE

May 1 – June 30, 2025

APPLY IN-PERSON:

Kings County Farm Bureau Office
870 Greenfield Ave., Hanford

FOR MORE INFORMATION:

www.ekrcd.org
(559) 309-4030
info@ekrcd.org

TECHNICAL ASSISTANCE AVAILABLE BY APPOINTMENT

Ag Commissioner's Compliance Report

Jimmy Hook, Agricultural Commissioner/Sealer

Measurement Standards Enforcement

As consumers, we purchase goods. Weather it is a gallon of gasoline, a pound of produce or a quart of motor oil, have you ever wondered if you can trust you are receiving exactly what you paid for. Did you actually received the 10 gallons of gas you pumped or is the grocery scale that weighs your vegetables at the time of purchase accurate? How do you know when you buy a 20 pound turkey or a 1 pound loaf of bread that you are getting the quantity stated on the package? The Kings County Sealer of Weights and Measures, through his duties, helps assure consumers get what they pay for.

The mission of the Kings County Department of Measurement Standards (Department) is to assure that *"Equity Prevails in the Marketplace"*. This protection extends into most every commercial transaction today. Since 1915, when the California State legislature established that each county shall have a Sealer of Weights and Measures, consumers in California have been protected in the marketplace. The Sealer in Kings County, Jimmy Hook, is empowered to perform these task through the authority of the California Department of Food and Agriculture's Division of Measurement Standards. One of the goals is to ensure that commodities sold by weight, measure, or count are labeled and packaged accurately. Enforcement by the Sealer's Department helps assure that only "correct" commercial devices are used and that transactions for goods are in compliance with the California Business and Professions Code and the California Code of Regulations.

The Department annually inspects over 3600 commercial devices operating in the county. These devices include fuel pumps at gas stations, scales at supermarkets and hardware stores, taximeters, odometers (ambulances), retail water meters, livestock scales and vehicle scales. Once tested and found to be "correct", a seal is affixed to the device and inspection date noted on the seal. "Correct" means that the device is both accurate and meets specifications.

The Department's heavy capacity weight truck is a certified standard with a weight of 46,200 pounds. This vehicle is primarily used to test the accuracy of vehicle scales, which are used to weigh the various crops as they are harvested

"Measurement Standards" continued on page 14

EXCELSIOR/KINGS RIVER
Resource Conservation District

FREE PUMP & IRRIGATION EFFICIENCY TESTING

Free tests offered to growers* in portions of Kings, Tulare, and Fresno Counties

*Members of the Socially Disadvantaged Farmers and Ranchers (SDFR) Community are encouraged to apply.
**SDFR Growers may qualify for additional pump tests and services.

WELLUP

WELL EVALUATION LAB - LEARNING, UNDERSTANDING, PLANNING

Objective:
Provide technical support to evaluate a farm's water supply health and plan for impacts of drought and water shortages.

Scan to Register

To sign up, scan the QR code or contact:
info@ekrcd.org or (559) 309-4030
For additional information,
visit our website at www.ekrcd.org

*Pump tests are provided for irrigation wells only

Connie Conway Returns to Lead USDA's Farm Service Agency in California

Kings County Farm Bureau (KCFB) is pleased to congratulate long-time friend and ally Connie Conway on her May 5 appointment as the new State Executive Director (SED) for the U.S. Department of Agriculture's Farm Service Agency (FSA) in California.

Secretary of Agriculture Brooke Rollins announced Conway's selection as part of the Trump Administration's effort to "put Farmers First again," noting that strong rural economies lift the nation as a whole. FSA Administrator Bill Beam echoed that sentiment, emphasizing that state directors occupy a pivotal role in delivering commodity, conservation, credit, and disaster-assistance programs "when rural communities need our support now more than ever."

Connie Conway, State Executive Director (SED) for the USDA Farm Service Agency (FSA)

A Proven Advocate for California Agriculture

This will be Conway's second tour at the helm of California FSA; she served in the same capacity during President Trump's first term. Since then, she has chaired the World Ag Expo—the world's largest outdoor farm exposition—and represented the Central Valley in the U.S. House of Representatives from 2022 to 2023.

Raised and still rooted in Tulare County, Conway has spent her career championing the needs of farmers and ranchers. That history includes countless collaborations with KCFB on water policy, disaster-relief outreach, and Farm Bill education. Our members know her as a straight-talking problem-solver who understands that timely, well-administered federal programs can mean the difference between surviving a tough season and shuttering the gates.

What Her Return Means for Growers

As SED, Conway will oversee the full slate of FSA offerings in California, from price-support and conservation programs to emergency loans and disaster assistance. Her deep Valley roots and first-hand knowledge of issues like groundwater sustainability and specialty-crop insurance position her to hit the ground running—an advantage as producers continue to navigate volatile markets, regulatory shifts, and weather extremes.

KCFB's leadership has already reached out to welcome her back and to reaffirm our shared commitment to putting farmers and ranchers first. We look forward to continued cooperation on:

- Streamlining program access for family farms of every size.
- Ensuring disaster-relief funds flow quickly during drought, flood, or freeze events.
- Advocating for practical conservation solutions that protect both natural resources and farm profitability.

Congratulations, Connie!

Please join KCFB in congratulating Connie Conway on her appointment. Her proven dedication to California agriculture—and her longstanding partnership with our Farm Bureau—gives us confidence that FSA programs will remain responsive to the unique challenges and opportunities faced by Central Valley producers.

We wish Connie every success in her new role and stand ready to support her efforts to keep California's farms thriving.

2025 CAFB Nominating Committee

Contributed by Taylor Hagata, Chair, 2025 CAFB Nominating Committee

In accordance with the CAFB Bylaws, the delegate confirmed Nominating Committee for the 2025 CAFB Election of Officers has convened, and their first meeting was held on May 21, 2025. During this meeting the committee approved process and guidelines to frame this year's selection process, and I was re-elected as Chairman of the committee.

To surface all interested candidates for office of President, 1st Vice President and 2nd Vice President, I am pleased to share that the candidate declaration period is now open. To be considered for office, interested candidates should contact Danielle Oliver, Director of Project Management, Executive Office, CAFB at doliver@cfbf.com to declare their intent to run for office. A candidate questionnaire will be forwarded to each interested individual along with submission instructions. All information will be provided to the Nominating Committee for review.

The deadline to declare as a candidate and complete and return the Candidate Profile is July 15, 2025.

Candidates for office should meet the following criteria as established by the CAFB Bylaws:

Article VI, Section 7

Each member of the Board of Directors must derive a majority of his or her gross income from farming operations, including as an owner, lessor, lessee, manager, officer or substantial shareholder of a corporate entity, in California in the year elected or during the five-year period prior to the election. Income paid to an elected officer by this corporation shall not be included in computing gross income.

The candidate selection process and subsequent election will be conducted in accordance with the CAFB Bylaws:

Article VIII, Section 4

The Committee shall solicit and vet and may nominate candidates for election to the offices of the President and the Vice Presidents. The Committee shall consist of the Chairman of the immediately preceding Nominating Committee and one agricultural member from each district, each of whom shall be elected at the annual meeting of members in each even-numbered year at a caucus by the State Delegates of each respective district. In addition, each caucus shall elect an alternate, who shall also be an agricultural member. The Committee shall elect its Chairman. The Committee shall convene no less than 180 days before the next annual meeting of members. The Committee shall review the qualifications of and interview each such candidate who responds to the solicitation. No less than 90 days before that annual meeting of members, the Committee shall announce any nominations it has made and may nominate for election at that meeting no more than one candidate for the office of President, one candidate for the office of 1st Vice President, and one candidate for the office of 2nd Vice President. The Committee shall publish to the members the names of all candidates who completed the Nominating Committee process for the meeting. Only candidates who completed the Nominating Committee process for the meeting at which the election will be held or who have filed with the Secretary endorsements of their nomination for a specified office or specified offices, signed by at least one State Delegate of each of 18 County Farm Bureaus attending the meeting at which the election is being held, shall be eligible for election at that meeting.

If you have any questions about these procedures, please contact Taylor Hagata at taylorhagata@gmail.com.

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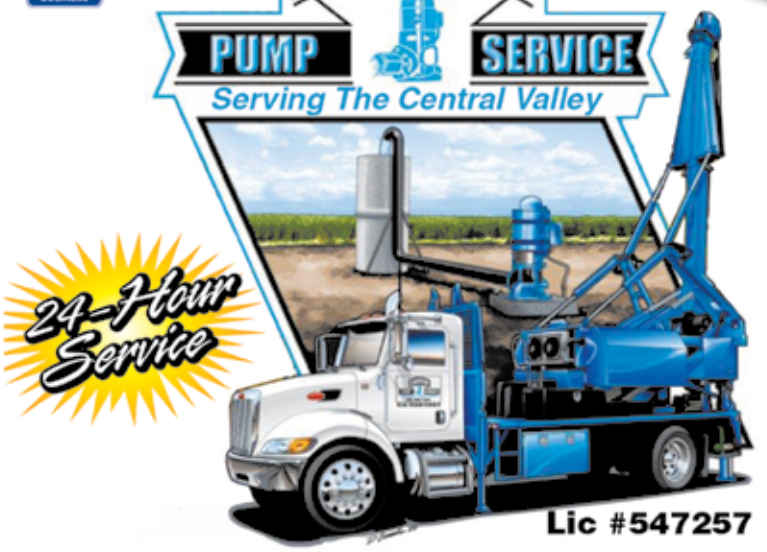

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EXPECT A HIGHER STANDARD

REALTOR, ADVISOR, SPECIALIST, AND INDUSTRY PARTNER - ALL IN ONE.

Schuil has been setting the bar for ag real estate for over 40 years. With deep roots in the Central Valley and a reach far beyond - providing buyers and sellers with the unique expertise and support that only our team can offer.

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6 WEST D STREET
LEMOORE CA 93245
(559) 924-3481
www.billingsleytireinc.com

Kings County Rural Crime Report

Contributed by Detective Santos

The month of May has been a slow month for us as far as copper wire thefts go (knock on wood). We have had one wire theft from an ag pump in the area of 6th Ave and Houston Ave where a 6 foot section of wire was taken. We also had an attempt to steal wire from another ag well in the 8 ½ Ave/Elder Ave area. The suspect cut the wires at the main box but was unable to take the wire. In this specific case the farmer had created a custom metal security system which prevented the suspect(s) from getting into the box. We recommend farmers attempt to reinforce electrical boxes at well sites, as this can be, and often is a deterrent.

The last couple of months we have been aggressively monitoring local recycling yards. Once we identify anyone who we believe is recycling stolen wire we go after them. We begin our investigation and if we can prove the wire was indeed stolen an arrest will be made. This has resulted in a substantial decrease in wire thefts in Kings County.

During the week of Friday, May 23, 2025, through Tuesday, May 27, 2025, animal rights activist group Direct Action Everywhere (DxE) hosted its Animal Liberation Conference (ALC) in Santa Rosa, CA. DxE is an international grassroots network of animal rights activists founded in 2013 in the San Francisco Bay Area. The conference's objective is to "bring together the most dedicated and motivated animal rights activists from around the world and empower the attendees to take bold, collective action to achieve revolutionary social and political change for animals."

On May 27, we received information from Fresno County Sheriff's Office Rural Crimes Unit that DxE would be protesting at the Harris Ranch feedlot in Coalinga. They monitored the protest without incident and informed us once DxE left the scene. We were then advised the convoy of about 20 vehicles was now traveling towards Kings County, but they were unsure of the specific location they could be going to. A short time later, the Kings County Sheriff's Office responded to a trespassing call for service at a goat dairy in the Stratford area. Multiple individuals from DxE were contacted by Deputies, and an investigation took place. A case will be forwarded to the Kings County District Attorneys Office for their review.

We encourage dairy owners and employees to continue to be vigilant. If a suspicious person(s) is located on or near your facility/property taking pictures, we recommend you do not contact them and call the Kings County Sheriff's Office dispatch number at (559) 584-9276 as soon as possible. We also ask you to attempt to take a picture of their vehicle, specifically license plate number, from a safe distance if possible. These photographs can be crucial to our investigations. If you have any other questions regarding DxE's mission you may look up their website at https://www.directactioneverywhere.com/ for further details.

If you have any questions, feel free to call me or any of our unit members at any time:

Detective Santos (559) 904-6893
Detective Estrada (559) 212-7512
Investigator Ward (559) 280-5441

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The framework's goal is to provide a gradual path toward sustainability while giving growers time to adapt their operations.

Subsidence Mitigation: Adaptive responses are being developed for areas most vulnerable to land subsidence. These include both monitoring and corrective actions that can be implemented quickly.

Stakeholder Communication: Tri-County acknowledged that building trust and transparency will be critical as draft policies are finalized. With the state placing greater weight on community engagement, the board is working to ensure that outreach efforts are timely, relevant, and accessible.

The emphasis at Tri-County remains on integration across geographies, policies, and stakeholder concerns.

What Comes Next: A Summer of Decisions

As summer approaches, stakeholders can anticipate more drafts, meetings, and opportunities for input. The work of SGMA is no longer theoretical. Decisions made now about transitional water, domestic well protection, and other key issues will have lasting consequences for the region.

If you are a landowner, advisor, or community member, here's how you can stay engaged:

- Register your wells within 90 days of pulling a permit and notify your GSA if timelines shift.
- Monitor allocation discussions in your GSA. Definitions of native yield and transitional pumping will affect your water use.
- Attend public meetings or review materials online. Each question asked strengthens the clarity of the final policies.
- Stay in touch with Farm Bureau and committee reps to remain informed on key issues like fees, recharge credit programs, and regional planning.

The region still has work to do, but this month's progress reflects a shared commitment to showing up, solving problems, and protecting the future of agriculture in the Central Valley.

Julie Martella is a writer, educator, and SGMA consultant working at the intersection of groundwater policy, stakeholder engagement, and agricultural resilience in the Tulare Lake Subbasin. She partners with advisory committees, Farm Bureaus, and local leaders to make SGMA implementation practical, transparent, and community driven.

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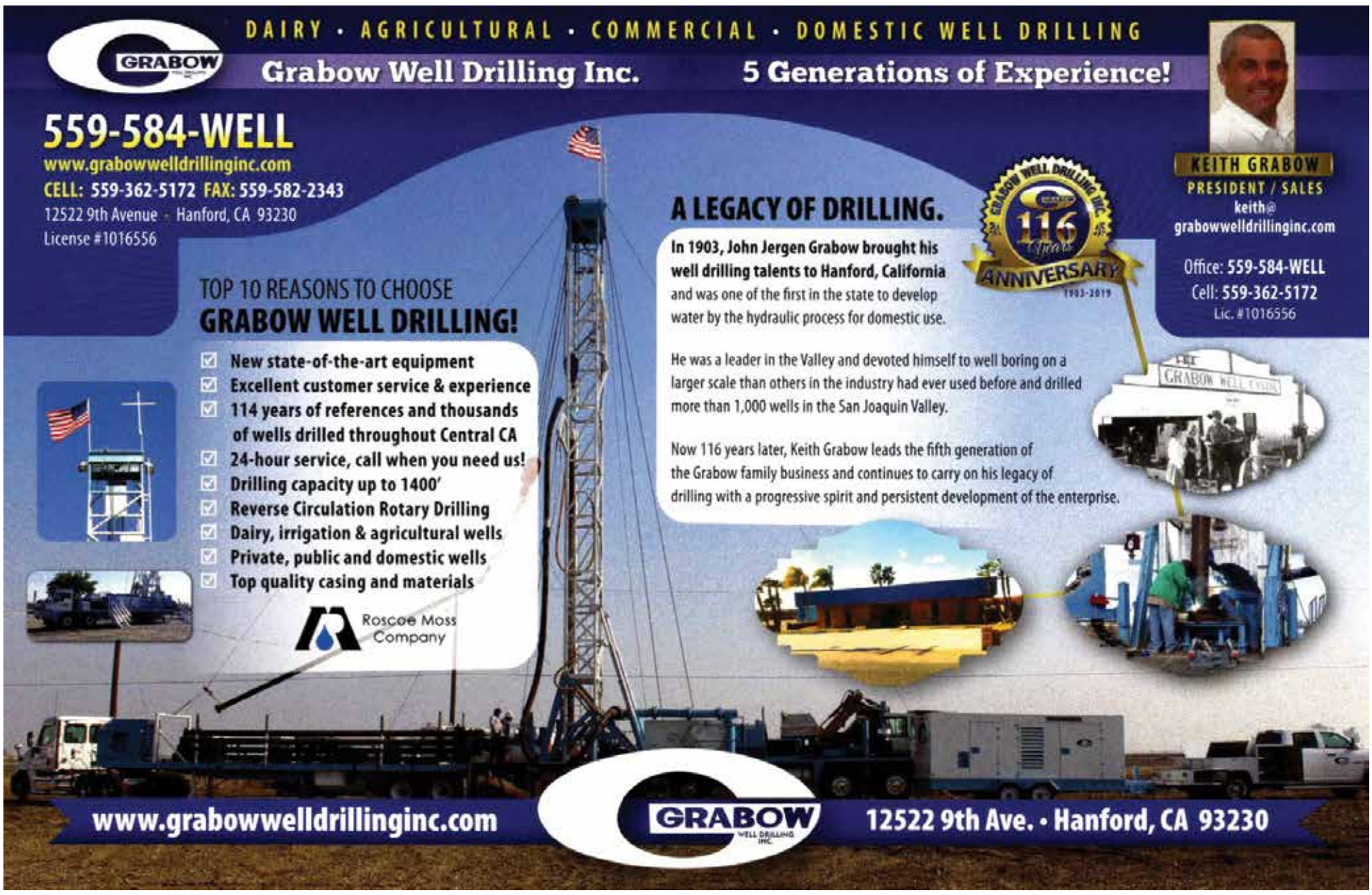
throughout the season. The individual twenty-four 1,000 pound weights carried on the vehicle can also be off-loaded on site to check smaller capacity devices, such as livestock and platform scales.

Stores in the county utilizing check stand scanners are inspected throughout the year. County inspectors conduct regular undercover purchases of various items, including sale items if applicable. The selected items are tallied at the register and the prices charged are verified against the lowest advertised price, either posted in the store or through advertisements. Businesses that package commodities for retail sale, such as supermarket meat counters and bakeries, as well as local businesses packaging their own cheese, nuts, and other agricultural commodities are also audited at least once per year to assure their products meet the declared quantity on their retail packaging statement meet net content requirements. Inspectors randomly sample packaged commodities, weigh or measure the contents and compare the labeled amount. Packages found to be short measure are subject to fines, removal for sale or other enforcement action.

The next time you are driving down the highway and need to stop for fuel, consider how easy it is to read the sign displaying the price of gasoline or diesel before pulling into the filling station. The Department assures petroleum signage meets the legal specifications to allow you the opportunity to decide to purchase fuel prior to entering the location. Proper markings on the pumps, including the fuel prices, octane rating, brand, and grade are inspected, as well as the postings notifying customers of the availability of free air and water and disabled driver services. Additional automotive products, such as coolant/anti-freeze, brake fluid, motor oil, and other lubricants are also inspected to assure they meet minimum SAE labeling specifications.

Rest assured that when you are out there making purchases on a daily basis, the Sealer of Weights and Measures in Kings County, as well as the rest of the counties in California, are protecting you through their daily inspection activities. Just look for the Seal!

If you have any questions on the services we perform or if you have a complaint regarding the transactions mentioned above, please contact our office at (559) 852-2830.



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If you have questions about your current sponsorship, would like to renew or join as a Friend of Farm Bureau, please contact Breanna at the KCFB office. 559-584-3557 or at blarman@kcfb.org

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